

Fate's Edge: Game Master's Guide

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Chapter 1

Introduction: The Weight of Choice

Welcome, Game Master. You hold a unique role in **Fate's Edge**. You are not a storyteller in solitude, nor a neutral referee. You are the **weaver of consequences**, the **architect of a living world**, and the **guide on a path where every choice echoes**. Your task is to breathe life into a realm of ancient magic, fallen empires, and stubborn, vibrant cultures—and then to let that world truly respond to the players' ambitions.

This is a game where power demands a price, where the past never truly sleeps, and where a single decision can reshape a nation or end an age. From the marble forums of Ecktoria to the mist-drenched fens of the Mistlands, the world is alive with stories waiting to be told. Your job is to provide the stage, set the stakes, and embrace the beautiful, chaotic ripple effects of player agency.

A World Alive with Consequences

In **Fate's Edge**, the fiction is the final authority. The rules in this book are not chains to bind your imagination, but **tools to give weight to your stories**. They provide a consistent framework for adjudicating risk, tracking progress, and ensuring that success and failure both drive the narrative forward in compelling ways.

Think of yourself as a conductor. The players provide the melody with their characters' actions and ambitions. You provide the harmony and rhythm with the world's response. The rules are your sheet music—a guide to creating a cohesive, dramatic piece, but one that allows for improvisation and adaptation.

Your judgment is the cornerstone of the game. If a rule doesn't serve the moment, change it. If a player's creative idea deserves to succeed, find a way to make it work. The ultimate goal is a collaborative, engaging story that everyone at the table helps to create.

The Core Philosophy: Narrative First

At the heart of **Fate's Edge** is a simple, powerful idea: **mechanics serve the story**. A dice roll is never just a binary pass/fail check. It is an event that changes the fictional landscape.

- A **Clean Success** means the plan works as intended—the guard is bribed, the lock clicks open, the argument sways the crowd.
- A **Success with Cost** means you get what you want, but the world pushes back—the guard takes the bribe but becomes a future liability, the lock opens but the mechanism is damaged,

the crowd is swayed but a rival noble takes note.

- A **Partial** means you make progress, but the situation remains unresolved—you can open the lock but it will take time and risk discovery, or you can sway part of the crowd but alienate another faction.
- A **Miss** means you fail, and the situation escalates—a new threat appears, a hidden factor is revealed, the stakes are raised.

This approach ensures that every roll matters. The story never stalls; it evolves.

Risk is the Engine of Drama

Fate's Edge is built on the principle that **meaningful risk creates compelling drama**. Safety is boring. It is when characters have something to lose—their reputation, their allies, their ideals, their lives—that their actions become truly heroic or tragically memorable.

Your primary tool for managing this risk is the **Story Beat (SB)** economy. When the dice show a 1, it is not merely a failure; it is the world reacting. The GM gains SB to introduce complications, escalate existing threats, or reveal hidden dangers. **Important:** SB are generated on *any* roll that produces a 1, whether the overall roll succeeds or fails. They are not punishments; they are fuel for an unpredictable, responsive narrative.

A successful sword swing might defeat an opponent, but a Story Beat spent could mean the blade is notched and less effective next time, or that the defeat draws the attention of a more powerful foe. The drama continues.

Characters Who Change the World

Character growth in **Fate's Edge** is not about accumulating abstract power. It is about **meaningful growth** rooted in the story. Players earn **Experience Points (XP)** by engaging with the world's challenges and complexities. They spend XP to improve their capabilities, acquire assets like a ship or a spy network, or unlock unique cultural talents.

This means character advancement is directly tied to the narrative. A character becomes a legendary commander by leading armies, not by killing monsters in a vacuum. They become a master wizard by uncovering forbidden lore and surviving the backlash, not by memorizing spells from a textbook. As the GM, you are the curator of this growth, presenting challenges that allow characters to evolve in ways that feel earned and impactful.

Your Toolkit

To help you guide the story, **Fate's Edge** provides a set of elegant, interconnected tools:

- **The Dice Pool:** Players roll a number of d10s equal to an Attribute + a Skill. Each die showing 6–10 counts as a **Success**. Each die showing 1 generates a **Story Beat (SB)** for you to spend. Compare the total number of Successes to a Difficulty Value (DV) set by the stakes.
- **Position & Effect:** Before a roll, you set the character's **Position** (Dominant, Controlled, or Desperate), which defines the stakes of failure and may grant a re-roll (failure for Dominant, success for Desperate). You also set their **Effect** (Limited, Standard, or Great), which describes what a clean success will achieve.
- **Clocks:** Visual trackers for ongoing challenges. A 4-segment clock might represent picking a complex lock, while an 8-segment **Campaign Clock** could track the rise of a villainous

faction.

- **The Deck of Consequences:** A standard 52-card deck used to generate inspired, thematic complications when SB are spent. The suit determines the nature of the complication (Social, Physical, etc.), adding a layer of fortune and flavor.

These tools are designed to be learned quickly and used intuitively, getting out of the way so you and your players can focus on the story.

How to Use This Book

This book is your guide to running the game.

- The first chapters cover the core principles and basic procedures.
- Later chapters delve into advanced systems for conflict, travel, and long-term play.
- The final sections provide guidance for high-tier campaigns, world-building, and the specific setting of the Amaranthine Sea region.
- The appendices offer practical advice for running scenarios and a comprehensive collection of tools and tables.

You don't need to memorize everything. Use this book as a reference. Return to it when you need clarification or inspiration. The most important chapters to internalize are those on the core philosophy (this chapter) and the basic action resolution.

Flavor is Free

Players and GMs: Remember that in **Fate's Edge**, **flavor is free!**

This means you can add descriptive details, cultural elements, and atmospheric touches to your actions without spending resources or requiring a dice roll. Want your Vhasian duelist to parry with a flourish taught in the royal fencing schools? Go ahead! Want to describe the eerie silence of a Valewood ruin when searching for clues? Perfect!

Flavor enriches the narrative and makes the world feel real and lived-in. It doesn't change the mechanical outcome, but it defines the *how* and the *why*. The GM should encourage this and reciprocate by painting vivid pictures of the world.

Mechanics determine success or failure, but flavor determines the story we tell about it.

A Guide for Veterans: Fate's Edge in a Nutshell

If you're experienced with other RPGs, here's a quick translation guide for how **Fate's Edge** handles common concepts:

	Traditional RPG Concept	Fate's Edge Approach
Ability Scores & Skills	Attributes (Body, Wits, etc.) + Skills (Melee, Lore, etc.)	form a dice pool.
Skill Checks	Roll Attribute+Skill dice pool. Count successes (6+).	Compare total successes to Difficulty Value (DV). Any 1s give the GM Story Beats (SB).
Hit Points / Health	Harm Track for injuries. Fatigue for exhaustion.	Consequences are narrative and mechanical.
Combat Rounds	Fiction-first. Actions are resolved based on narrative timing,	not rigid initiative.
Spell Slots / Mana	Magic uses the same core system. Any 1s on a magic roll generate SB as normal.	Powerful spells may require extra time, resources, or additional risk.
Saving Throws	Roll an appropriate Attribute+Skill combo to resist an effect (e.g., Body+Resolve to resist poison).	
Experience & Leveling Up	Gain XP through play. Spend XP to increase Attributes/Skills, acquire Talents, or buy Assets.	Growth is player-directed.
The key difference is a consistent, unified mechanic applied across all types of challenges, focused on narrative outcomes.		

Begin the Journey

Your role is a privilege and a creative challenge. You are a facilitator, a fan of the player characters, and the keeper of a world that will challenge and surprise them. Trust the rules to handle the tension, trust your players to drive the story, and trust yourself to weave it all together.

Now, take a deep breath. Shuffle the deck. Let the dice fall where they may.

It's time to guide the edge of fate.

Chapter 2

Running the Game: Core Procedures

How to Think in Fate’s Edge

Running **Fate’s Edge** is less about adjudicating difficulty and more about managing momentum. Your primary job is not to block success, protect outcomes, or simulate realism—it is to **frame pressure, track consequences, and let the fiction move forward**.

If you find yourself asking, “How hard should this be?” you are already one step too late.

Instead, ask:

- What is at stake right now?
- What happens if this goes wrong?
- What pressure is already in play?

The rules exist to answer those questions—not to replace them.

The Core Loop (In Practice)

Every meaningful action follows the same simple loop:

1. **Player declares intent and approach.**
2. **You state Position and set any relevant Clocks.**
3. **The roll resolves the moment.**
4. **You apply consequences and update the fiction.**

Do not search for the “right roll.” If the action matters, the procedure already applies.

Your Defaults

Your first rule: When in doubt, trust the fiction. The system will follow. When unsure, fall back on these defaults:

- **DV:** 3
- **Position:** Controlled
- **Consequence:** Fatigue, time pressure, or exposure
- **Clocks:** One short clock tied to the scene

Escalate only when the fiction demands it.

What You Are Not Doing

You are *not*:

- calling for rolls to gate progress
- inflating difficulty to “challenge” the players
- protecting NPC plans from disruption
- hiding information behind unnecessary checks

If the players act decisively, the world must respond decisively.

What You Are Doing

You *are*:

- stating Position clearly and confidently
- letting partials move the story forward
- spending Story Beats to make failure interesting
- allowing success to create new problems

The game works best when nothing stalls.

A Useful Reframe

Think of each scene as a **pressure engine**:

- Dice create outcomes
- Clocks track fallout
- Story Beats fuel escalation
- Boons reward risk

Your job is to keep that engine turning—not to decide where it ends.

Let the procedures do the work. Your attention belongs on the fiction.

2.1 Standard Rule: Player-Managed Modules

This rule makes each player the primary steward of their character-facing trackers (*modules*). It keeps table pace high, reduces hidden bookkeeping, and clarifies when mechanical thresholds trigger. The GM retains authority over world-facing clocks, faction fronts, and all major narrative consequences.

2.1.1 Scope (*What Counts as a Module*)

Player-managed modules are any **character-facing** clocks, counters, or discrete states that sit on a single character sheet:

- **Obligation** (per Patron or Symbol).
- **Corruption Clock** (e.g., Cantor).
- **Leash** (Summoned spirit strain) and **Spirit Bond Clock**.
- **Repertoire Clock** (Cantor) or similar progression clocks.
- **Asset States** (e.g., Symbol: Maintained / Neglected / COMPROMISED / SHATTERED).
- **Scene Counters** explicitly tied to a PC (e.g., Exposure on that PC, personal Buff/Debuff durations).

Not included: GM story resources (global **Story Beats**), location/faction clocks, and mystery/doom

fronts.

What Players Track (at a Glance)

11X

Module Owner Tick / Change Triggers (examples)

Obligation (by Patron) Player Invoke/Push/ritual text; Invoker *Borrowed Grace*; cracking a Symbol; bargain costs.

Corruption Clock Player Cantor Push; Resonant Rite; GM spends a Beat tied to the PC's occult actions.

Leash (Summoning) Player Harm to spirit; commands against nature; split focus; crossing [WARD] (DV = Cap).

Spirit Bond [4] Player Shared victories, mutual aid, meaningful attempts (*near-miss progress* once/session/type).

Repertoire [6] Player Learn a new unique Song/rite-as-song; practice milestones.

Asset State (Symbol) Player Maintenance/downtime checks; *Crack the Seal* → COMPROMISED; breakage → SHATTERED.

2.1.2 Core Principle

Players **immediately** mark their own modules when a rule says “mark +X” or a trigger fires. Threshold effects resolve as soon as they are reached.

2.1.3 Player Duties

1. **Mark Increases/Decreases on Cue.** When you Invoke a Rite, Push, spend/clear per rules text, or a trigger fires, update your module *now*, not later.
2. **Declare Thresholds.** If marking fills a clock or crosses capacity, say so aloud; thresholds resolve before the scene proceeds.
3. **State Ownership.** Keep per-Patron Obligation tallies distinct; track each Symbol's state if you use Symbols.
4. **Keep It Visible.** Use a tracker the GM and table can see (sheet boxes, index cards, or shared digital).

2.1.4 GM Duties

1. **Spot-Check.** At need, ask any player: current Obligation by Patron, Corruption segments, Leash state, Asset states.
2. **Enforce Thresholds.** When a player reports a threshold, apply the standard effects below *immediately*.
3. **Own the Fallout.** Patron intrusions, faction reactions, front clocks, and major narrative consequences remain GM authority.

2.1.5 Standard Thresholds & Effects

2.1.5.0.1 Obligation Capacity

$$\text{Obligation Capacity} = \text{Spirit} + \text{Presence}$$

- **Over Capacity:** Immediately mark +1 **Fatigue** per segment over capacity.

- **Over 2× Capacity:** Immediately clear all Fatigue, mark +1 **Harm (Stress)**, and a **Patron Intrusion** occurs (GM frames on-theme demand/complication).

2.1.5.0.2 Corruption Full When a **Corruption Clock** fills:

- Apply the last-Patron **benefit & burden** (per Patron table or setting guidance) to the PC (and any listed followers/retainers).
- **Reset** the Corruption Clock to empty.
- If the player chooses **Embrace Corruption**, convert the current Patron theme into a permanent boon/curse per §??.

2.1.5.0.3 Leash Full (Summoning) When the **Leash** fills:

- The spirit acts once to its nature, then **departs** (or turns hostile at GM discretion and fiction).

Leash Capacity: *Cap* + *Spirit* segments. (*Cap* is the outsider’s tier: Cap 1 for Lesser, Cap 3 for Greater.)

2.1.5.0.4 Symbol State (Invoker)

- **Maintained** → normal function. **Neglected** → GM may impose +1 DV to related rites.
- **Compromised** (e.g., *Crack the Seal*) → instant resolution per rules; mark extra Obligation; repair in Downtime or pay 1 XP.
- **Shattered** → unusable until replaced or ritually restored per fiction.

2.1.6 Table Procedure (90-Second Loop)

2.1.6.0.1 Start of Session Players read out: per-Patron **Obligation** totals, **Corruption** segments, standing **Asset States**, and any personal clocks at 3+.

2.1.6.0.2 End of Scene Quick pass: “*Any marks?*” Players tick modules from scene events. If a threshold triggers, resolve now.

2.1.6.0.3 Downtime Players apply clears (service, contrition, purification, study) to their own modules. GM verifies any costs or fiction.

2.1.7 Disputes & Order of Operations

If two marks would land simultaneously, apply them in the **least advantageous order for the acting character**, unless a rule specifies otherwise. The GM is final arbiter.

2.1.8 Accessibility & Tools

Use highly visible trackers: bold boxes on sheets, poker chips for segments, or a shared table of per-Patron Obligation. Keep modules at-a-glance to minimize interruption.

2.1.9 Worked Micro-Examples

- **Invoker Rites Twice:** Vessa Invokes two different Patrons. She marks each Patron’s **Obligation** separately. Hitting capacity with Patron A causes Fatigue; Patron B remains below capacity.
- **Cantor Pushes:** Jorel Pushes a Song (mark +1 Corruption). That fill triggers the last-Patron boon/burden immediately; then he resets to 0.

- **Summoner Clash:** Kestra's Cap 3 elemental takes Harm and crosses a [WARD]; she ticks her **Leash** twice. On fill, the elemental flares once and departs.

The Core Loop: Your First 10 Games

Start here for your first session! Ignore advanced systems until comfortable.

1. Player states Goal & Action (Attribute + Skill)
2. GM sets simple DV (2-5)
3. Player rolls. Count Successes (6+)
4. GM consults Outcome Matrix. **Ignore Boons for now. Use simple complications on Partial/Miss.**

*Once comfortable, add: **Boons** | **Story Beats** | **Clocks***

First Game Scenario: The Sunstone Tower

Premise: The party is hired to infiltrate the ruined Sunstone Tower and retrieve a magical sunstone before rival treasure hunters do. This scenario uses a limited rules subset perfect for beginners.

- **Ignore for this scenario:** Boons, Corruption, intricate magic subsystems, detailed Follower/Asset upkeep.
- **Focus on:** Core dice pool, Success/Partial/Miss outcomes, Position, Clocks.
- **Character Setup:** Use pregenerated characters or create simple ones with 20 XP and 2–3 clear hooks.

GM Prep in 10 Minutes

[Sunstone Tower Prep Checklist]

- Name 3 NPCs: hirer, rival deliver, tower spirit (or echo).
- Write 1 sentence for each scene: Approach, Interior, Sunstone Chamber.
- Create 2 clocks: **Guardian Alert** [4] and **Tower Collapse** [6].
- Decide 1 twist: rival arrives early, tower shifts, or sunstone is not what it seems.

Scene 1: The Approach

Lane Marker: Skill Challenge with a Clock

GM Focus: Practice calls for DV and Partial outcomes. For this intro, tick the **Guardian Alert** [4] clock on a Partial or Miss.

The tower stands on a cliffside. Players must navigate three challenges:

- Cross the crumbling bridge (Athletics) – DV 3
- Scale the cliff face (Athletics/Strength) – DV 4
- Sneak past the stone guardians (Stealth) – DV 3

Guardian Alert Clock [4]: Each Partial or Miss advances the clock by 1. If filled, guardians activate and pursue; treat them as a single *Tower Guardian* threat with a simple [4] Harm track.

Scene 2: The Tower Interior

This scene teaches **Position** and **environmental stakes**.

- **Dominant:** “You have the high ground on the crumbling staircase, looking down on the patrol.”
- **Controlled:** “The hallway is dark but quiet. You can take your time, but there might be traps.”
- **Desperate:** “The floor gives way beneath you as you lunge for the door!”

[How to Set Position in Play]

- **Listen First:** Hear the player’s intent and approach. What are they actually doing in the fiction?
- **Assess the Situation:** Consider leverage, opposition, time pressure, exposure, and consequences. Ask yourself: *How forgiving is the world right now?*
- **Assign the Position:**
 - **Dominant:** The character has clear leverage, surprise, or overwhelming advantage.
 - **Controlled:** The situation is stable; mistakes are recoverable.
 - **Desperate:** The character is exposed, rushed, cornered, or facing serious danger.
- **State It Clearly:** Say it out loud before the roll. *“This is Desperate. If it goes wrong, the consequences will be serious.”*

Reminder: Position is a statement of risk and consequence, not a reward or a penalty. It frames what failure *means*.

Scene 3: The Sunstone Chamber

The chamber is collapsing as rival delvers close in. Use a simple [6] clock for the collapse. Each round, the clock ticks up by 1. On each Miss, advance it by an extra 1 segment.

- **Goal:** Retrieve the sunstone and escape before the clock fills.
- **On Fill:** The chamber seals. Escape requires a final, Desperate group action.

Lane Marker: One New Idea at a Time

Scene 1: Clocks *only*.

Scene 2: Add *Position*.

Scene 3: Combine *Clocks + Position*. Reserve Boons, Corruption, and advanced magic for later sessions.

2.2 Learning Through Examples

This section walks the same situation through multiple passes, adding one rule at a time. Use it as a mental template when you improvise.

Example 1: Core Loop Only

Example 1 – No SB, No Boons

Lyra tries to sneak past the guardian in a narrow hallway. (Agility + Stealth = 5d10).

The GM says it’s a normal risk, DV 3, Controlled Position.

She rolls and gets: 3, 5, 6, 7, 9 ⇒ 3 successes (6, 7, 9).

DV 3 with 3 successes is a **Success**.

GM: “You slip past the guardian quietly. You’re in position behind it if you want to act.”

Example 2: Add Story Beats Only**Example 2 – Adding Story Beats**

Same situation. Lyra rolls 5d10 and gets: 1, 4, 6, 6, 8.

Successes: 3 (6, 6, 8). She also rolled a 1, which makes 1 Story Beat (SB) for the GM.

DV 3 with 3 successes is still a **Success**, but the GM now has 1 SB.

GM Spend (1 SB = Minor Complication):

“You get past the guardian, but your cloak snags and tears. The sound echoes – the next room has a -1 Position penalty for stealth checks.”

Example 3: Add Boons Only**Example 3 – Adding Boons**

Later, Lyra attempts to scale a loose stone wall (Athletics + Agility = 4d10). DV 3.

She rolls: 2, 3, 4, 5. Zero successes = **Miss**.

Instead of only consequence, the GM awards **2 Boons**.

GM: “You slip and land hard, taking 1 Harm. Mark 2 Boons – you can use them later to turn the tide.”

On her next attempt, Lyra spends 1 Boon to re-roll a die, turning a failure into a success. The player feels the sting of failure *and* the promise of payoff.

Example 4: Putting It Together**Example 4 – SB + Boons + Position**

The party is fleeing as the tower begins to collapse. A crumbling staircase stands between them and the exit.

GM: “This is Desperate. DV 4 to get everyone across safely.”

Lyra leads, rolling 6d10 (Agility + Athletics + help). She gets: 1, 2, 6, 7, 7, 9.

Readout:

- 4 successes (6, 7, 7, 9) vs DV 4 = Success.
- 1 rolled 1 = 1 SB to the GM.
- Desperate Position means high risk if there had been fewer successes.

GM: “You all make it across, but the last step collapses behind you. I spend 1 SB: your exit path is gone. You’ll need a new way out.”

Lesson: Even on a success, SB let you bend the fiction toward drama without erasing the player’s win.

2.3 The Core Resolution Cycle

When a player rolls, they engage the world through risk, consequence, and discovery. Follow these steps:

1. **Declare Action & Approach:** Player states intent, Attribute + Skill.
2. **Set Difficulty Value (DV):** Based on narrative stakes.
3. **Establish Position:** Dominant, Controlled, or Desperate.

4. **Roll Pool of d10s.**
5. **Count Successes (6+) and Story Beats (1s).**
6. **Check Against DV** using Outcome Matrix.
7. **Apply Outcome:** Success, Partial, or Miss.
8. **Spend SB** for complications and twists.

2.3.0.0.1 Success. The action succeeds as intended. No Story Beats are generated unless specified by the roll or effect. The fiction advances cleanly in the player's favor.

2.3.0.0.2 Success with Cost. The action succeeds, but generates **Story Beats**. The success stands; the cost is represented by the GM spending those Story Beats, ideally applied to the inciting action or its immediate consequences.

2.3.0.0.3 Miss. The action fails to achieve its intended effect and generates **Story Beats**. The GM uses those Story Beats to introduce complications, advance opposition, or shift the situation against the character.

2.3.0.0.4 Partial Success (GM Adjudication). A Partial indicates that the action makes progress, but does not fully resolve the situation. How that progress manifests is determined by the GM, based on context, scale, and narrative stakes.

Partial results may:

- Improve the character's **Position** on a follow-up attempt
- Reduce the effective **DV** of the next roll
- Achieve the goal at reduced scale or limited duration
- Succeed fully, but generate a **Story Beat** as cost or complication
- Reveal information or create a new opportunity instead of immediate resolution

2.3.0.0.5 Example: Lockpicking. A character attempts to pick a DV 3 lock.

- With **1 success** (Partial), the GM rules the lock is loosened but not opened. The character gains *Controlled Position* on the next attempt.
- With **2 successes** (Strong Partial), the lock opens — but the GM chooses to spend the generated **Story Beat**, upgrading the result to a *Success with Cost* (the lock jams behind them, or someone hears the click).

2.3.0.0.6 Guiding Principle. Partials represent *meaningful progress*. The GM may convert progress into advantage, resolution, or complication, depending on what best serves the fiction.

[Position Effects] IX

Position Mechanical Effect

Dominant May re-roll one failure (die < 6).

Controlled Default state; no re-rolls.

Desperate Must re-roll one success (die 6+), keeping the second result.

[Difficulty Ladder – Beginner Focus] IX

DV When to Use

- 2 Routine: Clear path, no pressure, almost guaranteed.
 - 3 Default: Mild challenge, some risk, use this most often.
 - 4 Hard: Serious opposition, bad angle, or strong resistance.
 - 5+ Extreme: Save for major boss encounters or dramatic gambles.
-

2.4 Story Beats: The Engine of Drama

Every time a player rolls a 1, you gain Story Beats (SB). These are narrative tools, not punishments.

[SB Spend Menu] IX

SB Cost Simple Complications

- 1 SB Minor: Noise, distraction, small setback, lost gear.
 - 2 SB Moderate: Alarm raised, new threat enters, lose advantage.
 - 3+ SB Major: Reinforcements, scene shifts, stakes escalate.
-

Failing Forward with SB

- **On Success:** Use SB to add texture. The hero wins, but something changes.
- **On Partial:** The hero gets what they wanted *and* you spend SB to add cost or threat.
- **On Miss:** You can spend SB to make the setback sharper, broader, or longer-lasting.

Lane Marker: One Complication per Roll

When in doubt, spend SB on *one* clear complication instead of many small ones. Name it plainly—“Guard Alerted”, “Floor Cracked”, “Oath Owed”—and move on.

Be **aggressive** with Story Beats, but never arbitrary:

- Do not hoard SB—unused pressure is wasted momentum.
- Do not invent contrived consequences that ignore the fiction.
- Spend SB to *sharpen what already matters*, not to add noise.

A single, well-chosen complication should change the situation, not just decorate it.

2.5 Combat Made Simple

Combat uses the same core loop. The only difference is that the stakes are higher and usually more immediate.

[Combat Quick Reference]

- **Initiative:** No fixed order. Ask: “Who acts next?” Follow the fiction.
- **Actions:** Each turn, a character can move and take one meaningful action.
- **Position Matters:** Flanking or ambush → Dominant; surrounded or exposed → Desperate.
- **Use Clocks:** Track enemy morale [6], environmental dangers [4], and boss thresholds.

Three-Beat Combat Structure

When you feel lost in a fight, fall back on three beats:

1. **Opening Exchange:** Establish where everyone is and what they want.
2. **Turning Point:** Spend SB or tick clocks to change the situation (reinforcements, terrain shifts).
3. **Final Gamble:** Make the last few rolls matter – higher DV, Desperate Position, or big rewards.

Example: SB in Combat

The party fights bandits on a collapsing bridge.

On a Partial, the GM spends 2 SB: “You push them back, but the bridge loses another support. The *Bridge Collapse* [4] clock advances.”

Now every action is also about whether they escape in time.

2.6 Clocks & Fronts

Clocks are visual trackers for threats, progress, and looming changes. They keep pressure visible and shared.

Basic Clock Usage

- **Size:** Use [4] for small scenes, [6] for bigger problems, [8] for arcs.
- **Advance On:** Misses, certain Partials, or SB spends.
- **Name It:** “Alarm Raised [4]” or “Floodwaters Rise [6]” is better than a blank circle.

[Beginner Clock Limits]

- No more than 3 active clocks per scene.
- Only 1–2 clocks should matter to the current roll.
- Say out loud when you tick a clock and why.

Mini-Fronts for Short Arcs

A *Front* is a cluster of related clocks and threats.

- **Example Front:** “Rival Delvers of the Sunstone Tower”
- **Clocks:** “Rivals Close In [6]”, “Tower Integrity [6]”, “Rival Reputation [4]”.
- Each time you spend SB, consider ticking one of these clocks.

2.7 Ready for More? Add These Systems

Once you’re comfortable with the core loop, introduce these modules one at a time. Treat each as a new lane marker.

Boons

Boons reward players for pushing their luck.

- **On Miss:** Gain 2 Boons.
- **On Partial:** Gain 1 Boon.
- **Spend:** Re-roll a die, add +1 Effect, or seize a small advantage (GM-approved).

Start with *re-roll only*. Once players are comfortable, add the other options.

Advanced Magic

- **Basic:** Use simple Tag-based magic (single roll, single tag).
- **Intermediate:** Add Runekeepers after 2–3 sessions, when everyone understands SB and Clocks.
- **Advanced:** Introduce Invokers and ritual magic for groups that enjoy planning and complex payoffs.

Followers, Assets, and Domains

Add persistent resources when the group cares about territory, organizations, or long-term projects.

- Start with 1 simple Follower or Asset each.
- Tie them to clocks: “Caravan Reputation [6]”, “Temple Influence [4]”.
- Spend SB to threaten or complicate these resources.

2.8 Session Flow: A GM Cognitive Checklist

Use this as a quiet mental script. You do not need to say any of it out loud.

Opening 10 Minutes

- Ask: “What does everyone want out of tonight?” (goal, vibe, focus).
- Recap 2–3 key facts and 1 unresolved clock.
- Ask each player: “What is your character worried about right now?”

During Play

- Before a roll: Name DV, Position, and stakes.
- After a roll: Say the outcome type (Success/Partial/Miss) first, then the fiction.
- Between scenes: Look at clocks. Ask, “Which one should move? What changes in the world?”

Closing 10 Minutes

- Ask: “What was your favorite moment?” (signals what to do more of).
- Note any clocks that reached halfway or full.
- Jot 2 bullet points: “Next time on Fate’s Edge...” as hooks.

Quick GM Cheat Sheet

- **DV Default:** 3 (adjust ± 1 for ease/difficulty).
- **Position:** Controlled (normal), Dominant (advantage), Desperate (risk).
- **SB Spend:** 1=minor, 2=moderate, 3+=major complication.
- **Max Clocks:** 3 per scene to avoid overwhelm.
- **Golden Rule:** When in doubt, make a ruling that keeps the story moving.

Remember: The goal is to tell an exciting story together. These rules are tools, not tests. Start simple, add complexity when you’re ready, and keep your lane markers clear: one new idea at a time, one clear consequence per roll, and one or two clocks that really matter.

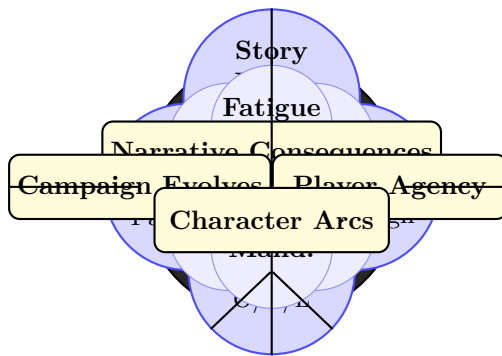


Figure 2.1: Fate's Edge systems: the Core Loop drives SB/Clocks/Modules/Boons; pressure systems store consequences; narrative outcomes feed back into play.

The Lazy DV Table (GM Guidance)

Use this table when you need a quick ruling. DV represents the *significance of the challenge*, not the intrinsic difficulty of the task.

clp7.2cm	
DV Label When to Use It	
2 Easy	Competent effort; setbacks cause inconvenience or exposure.
3 Standard	Meaningful challenge with real stakes.
4 Hard	Time pressure, opposition, danger, or contested effort.
5 Extreme	High-risk actions where failure escalates the situation.
6 Legendary	Apex-tier challenges, climactic scenes, or mythic feats.

2.8.0.0.1 Default Rule: For a meaningful challenge, assume **DV = Tier + 2**. If the obstacle is beneath the characters' tier, do not roll.

Difficulty comes from **Position**, **Clocks**, and **Consequences**—not higher DVs.

Lazy Consequence Mapping

Consequences should scale with *pressure and tier*, not punish routine failure.

p3cmp9cm	
Pressure Default Consequence	
Low	Fictional complication, lost time, new exposure
Moderate	Fatigue (1) , Clock advance, Position downgrade
High	Fatigue (2) , Harm 1, major Clock advance
Severe	Harm 2+, capture, separation, or irreversible loss

2.8.0.0.2 Scaling Guidance:

- At higher Tiers, prefer **Fatigue**, **Clock pressure**, and **collateral fallout** over raw Harm.
- Harm represents failure to manage risk—not routine opposition.
- Equipment loss, asset damage, or narrative loss should follow clear fictional cause.

Harm is a consequence of escalation, not a default penalty.

Why Fatigue Comes Before Harm

2.8.0.0.3 Design Intent. Fatigue represents strain, stress, and narrowing options. Harm represents injury, trauma, or lasting damage.

Fatigue:

- Pressures future rolls
- Forces resource decisions (Boons, Talents, retreat)
- Encourages pacing and teamwork
- Keeps characters active in the scene

Harm:

- Removes options
- Shortens scenes
- Risks sidelining characters
- Escalates toward recovery or downtime

2.8.0.0.4 GM Guidance. Use Fatigue to say: “*You can keep going, but it will cost you.*” Use Harm to say: “*You cannot ignore this.*” If a consequence does not meaningfully change player decisions, it should not be Harm.

On Equipment Damage (Read This!)

2.8.0.0.5 Default Rule: Do **not** compromise equipment trivially.

Equipment damage should be:

- Rare
- Telegraphed
- Thematic
- Tied to meaningful stakes

2.8.0.0.6 Why. Trivial equipment loss:

- Feels punitive rather than dramatic
- Creates bookkeeping without tension
- Undermines player investment
- Disproportionately punishes martialists

2.8.0.0.7 Better Alternatives. Before damaging gear, consider:

- Temporary disadvantage (*jammed, misaligned, unstable*)
- Increased Fatigue to compensate for strain
- Clock advancement representing wear or attention
- Forced repositioning or exposure

2.8.0.0.8 When to Damage Equipment. Equipment damage is appropriate when:

- The fiction clearly targets the item
- A major Story Beat is spent
- The moment is climactic or symbolic
- The player knowingly risked it

Example: A shattered shield during a last stand is meaningful. A snapped sword on a routine miss is not.

DV Is Not Difficulty — It Is Commitment

A higher DV does *not* mean:

- harder math
- better challenge
- greater realism

A higher DV means:

- fewer partials
- fewer Boons
- faster escalation
- less room to recover

2.8.0.0.9 GM Heuristic. If you want:

- more tension → add Clocks
- more danger → spend Story Beats
- more drama → worsen Position
- more consequence → choose harsher costs

Raise DV only when the *fiction itself* demands commitment.

High-Tier Reminder

At Tier IV–V:

- dice pools are larger
- consequences carry greater narrative weight

Do **not** inflate DV to compensate.

High-tier difficulty emerges naturally from:

- Boon scarcity (fewer misses and partials mean fewer Boons)
- asset activation costs
- multi-threaded Clocks
- long-tail consequences

Let power feel earned, strained, and visible—never trivial.

2.8.0.0.10 GM Mantra.

Set the DV low. Make the world react honestly. Let the pressure do the work.

First Session Cheat Sheet: The Pressure Engine in Action

[The Pressure Engine at a Glance]

This table distills the core mindset into actionable steps for your first session. It complements—not repeats—the principles in *How to Think in Fate’s Edge* by providing concrete actions at critical moments.

p3.5cmp4cmp4.5cm		
	Critical Moment	What to Do
		Why It Works
Before the Session	Write the GM Mantra on a notecard: “ <i>Set the DV low. Make the world react honestly. Let the pressure do the work.</i> ” Place it where you’ll see it.	Mindset matters first. This primes you to trust the system before rules.
Introducing the Game	Say: “ <i>Your failures will create opportunities. When you roll a 1, you gain power to shape the story.</i> ”	Reframes failure as narrative fuel. Stops players from fearing rolls.
Setting the Scene	Before any roll:	
	1. Listen: “What are you actually doing?”	
	2. Assign Position	
	3. State it aloud: “This is <i>[Position]</i> .”	
	Makes Position the anchor.	This is the single most important step—the engine starts here.
When Players Roll	Note every 1 immediately. Ask: “What does this mean for the story?”	1s are the narrative engine. Never skip this step—they create momentum.
On Partial Success	Don’t say “You succeed, but...” Say: “You succeed at a cost. What does this success cost?”	Makes the scene dynamic. This is where the story grows.
When Setting DV	Start with DV 3 as your default. Only adjust if the fiction demands it.	Prevents overcomplication. 90% of scenes thrive at DV 3.
When Stuck	Ask: “What’s at stake right now?” Not: “How hard should this be?”	Aligns with the core system logic. This replaces difficulty math with pressure framing.
After the Session	Write one sentence: “ <i>What I learned: [your insight].</i> ”	Cements the mindset. Focus on what matters, not what went “wrong.”
When in Doubt	Set Position to Controlled , DV to 3 , and ask: “What happens if this goes wrong?”	The golden rule. This solves 95% of first session dilemmas.

2.8.0.0.11 Final Note for GMs This table is not a rulebook. It is a compass. Use it until the rhythm of play becomes second nature.

Your First Combat: A GM Cheat Sheet

>p3cm p10cm

Stage What to Do (Simplified)

Stage What to Do (Simplified)

Setup Describe the immediate situation clearly: “You’re in a narrow hallway, back to the wall. Three bandits advance.”

Skip initiative. Follow narrative flow—who acts first should be obvious.

Start at **Controlled Position** unless the fiction strongly says otherwise.

Position **Dominant**: Clear advantage (surprise, leverage, flanking).

Controlled: Normal fighting (*most rolls*).

Desperate: Cornered, outnumbered, or everything at stake.

The GM always states Position before the roll. “This is Desperate. If it goes wrong, you’ll be disarmed.”

Dice Pool Roll **Attribute + Skill** (e.g., Body + Melee).

No extra math. No stacking modifiers.

Player states approach in fiction: “I charge in with my sword.”

Outcomes **Clean Success**: Goal achieved cleanly.

Success with Cost: Goal achieved; spend 1 SB for a complication.

Partial: Progress at reduced scale, improved position, or a hard choice.

Miss: No progress; spend SB to escalate the situation.

Story Beats Spend SB aggressively but cleanly—never arbitrarily:

1 SB — Minor complication “*Steel sparks; you gain ground, but the noise carries.*”

2 SB — Moderate setback “*Your ally is knocked off-balance; their next roll is Desperate.*”

3+ SB — Major shift “*Reinforcements arrive. New Clock: Escalation [4].*”

Always spend on *one clear consequence per roll*.

Clocks Use **one clock maximum** in the first combat (e.g., “Enemy Harm [4]”).

Advance clocks on Miss or Success-with-Cost.

All clocks should be visible to players.

Ignore layered or tactical clocks for Session One.

Multiple Enemies Treat a group as **one threat** unless individuals act differently.

One clock covers the group. If one foe is distinct, give them their own clock.

Boons Players may spend 1 Boon to:

- Re-roll a single die
- Improve Position by one step
- Activate an on-scene Asset

Players gain **2 Boons on a Miss, 1 Boon on a Partial**.

What to Ignore No miniatures or grids — theater of the mind only.

No advanced maneuvers or combos.

No fatigue-position interactions yet.

No multi-clock combat frameworks.

Next Session Add *one* new element:

- A second clock, or
- Environmental pressure, or
- A structured combat arc

Introduce the Three-Beat Combat structure later.

2.8.0.0.12 First Combat Rule of Thumb. Describe the situation → State Position → Roll → Apply outcome → Spend SB once → Move forward.

If the scene is moving, you're doing it right.

The GM Mindset: Three Guiding Principles

>p0.25 X

Principle Guidance

1. Don't Fear Failure The dice are not your opposition—they are your collaborators. When unsure how to rule something, ask: *“Does this create a more interesting story?”* If yes, lean into it. The system rewards bold GM decisions with momentum, not penalties.

2. Spend SB to Create Every Story Beat you spend should open a new door, not close one. A SB spent on *“the door slams shut”* is weaker than one spent on *“the door slams shut—but the echo draws guards closer.”* Favor movement, pressure, and consequences over hard stops.

3. The Real DV Is in Stakes If a scene feels flat, raise the stakes—not the difficulty. Before the roll, be clear about what failure means. When players ask *“What happens if I fail?”*, answer honestly. That answer is where tension lives, not in higher numbers.

Encounter in Action: The Ambush at Raven's Ford

This example shows how the core systems—narrative initiative, Story Beats (SB), Boons, Bonds, and damage—come together in play. The party consists of **Thane** (fighter), **Sariel** (rogue), and **Kestra** (mage).

Setup

The group is crossing a rope bridge when two bandits attack from the far side. The GM sets the scene:

“The bridge sways under your feet. Two crossbowmen take aim from behind a boulder. Thane, you’re closest to them. Sariel is mid-bridge, Kestra still on the near cliff.”

No initiative is rolled. The GM asks: “Who acts first?” Thane says, “I charge.” The GM agrees—he’s closest and has momentum.

Round 1 — Thane’s Turn

Thane rushes the bandits. GM says: “You’re exposed on the bridge, crossbows trained on you—Desperate Position, DV 3 to reach them before they shoot.” Thane rolls Body + Melee (6d10): 7, 5, 4, 2, 1, 1 → two successes (7 only). One success short. Miss.

2.8.0.0.13 Result: The GM gains 2 SB (two 1s) *and* the player gains 2 Boons (Miss). GM narrates:

“You make it halfway, but a bolt grazes your arm. Mark Harm 1. The bandits draw swords—they’re in Close now.”

Enemy Turn (No Roll?)

Because Thane closed the distance, the bandits simply “draw swords” as a consequence of his Miss. Enemies do not automatically roll to attack. The GM uses the 2 SB from Thane’s roll:

- **Spend 1 SB:** “The second bandit kicks a loose plank. The bridge lurches—everyone make a Body + Athletics test (DV 3) or be knocked Prone.”
- **Spend 1 SB:** “Sariel, your footing slips; your next action is Desperate.”

No enemy attack roll needed. SB shape the fiction directly.

Sariel fails her test; she is Prone. Kestra succeeds.

Player Turn — Sariel Uses a Boon

Sariel wants to stab the nearest bandit from prone. “Can I roll?” GM: “Desperate, DV 3.” She rolls: no successes. Miss. She gains 2 Boons (now has 2 total). Before the GM narrates failure, she **spends 1 Boon** to re-roll one die. Re-roll comes up 6 → adds one success, turning Miss into Partial. GM: “You slash his leg—he drops to one knee, but your dagger is lodged. It’ll take a moment to free it.”

Bond Transfer

Kestra sees Sariel struggling. She has a Bond with Sariel (“She saved me once; I owe her”). As a free action (Tier III+ rule), Kestra **transfers 2 Boons** to Sariel, saying, “I shout, ‘The knife! Pull it toward you!’” Sariel now has 3 Boons.

Kestra’s Turn — Boon for Environmental Effect

Kestra wants to use magic to collapse part of the bridge behind the bandits, cutting off their retreat. She has the **Spellcraft** talent and the [EARTH] and [BREAK] tags. GM says: “Controlled, DV 4. Spend a Boon to improve Position to Dominant?” Kestra spends 1 Boon (now Dominant, DV 4). She rolls successfully, generating 1 SB (a 1). The GM spends that SB immediately:

“The bridge splinters—the bandits are isolated! But the shockwave also loosens the rope on your side. New Clock: Bridge Collapse [1]”

Chapter 3

Managing Resources

In **Fate's Edge**, resources are narrative levers, not inventory lists. From the last sip of water in the sun-scorched sands of Akilan to the fragile loyalty of a Ykrul war-band, every resource tells a story, and every story demands its price. As the GM, you are the keeper of these vital threads—the weaver of scarcity and abundance. This chapter shows how to manage the systems that fuel mortal ambitions and epic campaigns.

3.1 Supply Clock: The Pulse of Survival

The **Supply Clock** tracks the party's access to essentials: food, water, gear, and logistical support. It is a shared resource for the entire group—a narrative lever that tightens tension when the party is isolated, pursued, or cut off from civilization.

Supply Clock States

[Supply Clock Conditions] IX

Segments Filled Narrative Effects

- 0 (Full) Well-equipped and prepared; no penalty.
 - 1 (Low) Minor complications: bland rations, damaged arrows, thinning waterskins.
 - 2 (Dangerous) Each character gains *Fatigue 1* as scarcity takes its toll.
 - 3 (Empty) Severe penalties: starvation, dehydration, equipment failure imminent.
-

Filling the Clock

The Supply Clock advances when the world turns against the party's preparations:

- Extended travel through hostile lands without proper provisioning.
- The GM spends 2+ Story Beats (SB) on logistics failures or environmental hardships.
- The party chooses to travel light for speed or stealth.
- Failed Survival or Craft rolls related to hunting, foraging, or repair.

Emptying the Clock

Hope returns when the party finds respite:

- Reaching civilization resets the clock to Full.
- A group Survival check (Wits + Survival, DV 2) in favorable conditions clears 1 segment.
- Downtime spent in relative safety removes 1 segment.
- Successful provisioning (a good hunt, a discovered cache) can reduce segments.

Example: A week-long sea passage with uncertain winds. A failed Navigation roll causes the GM to spend 2 SB—filling two segments as supplies spoil in the damp hold. The party is now at Low Supply. A second failed roll fills another segment—Dangerously Low. Fatigue sets in. The sea gnaws at their endurance.

3.2 Fatigue: The Weight of the World

Fatigue represents the cumulative toll of journeying through a world that rarely offers comfort: exhaustion that seeps into bones, hunger that hollows cheeks, strain that clouds judgment. Each level of Fatigue forces the character to **re-roll one success** on their next action.

Fatigue Effects

[Fatigue Progression] IX

Fatigue Level Effect

- 1 Re-roll one success (minor exhaustion, distracted)
 - 2 Re-roll one success cumulative (noticeable weariness)
 - 3 Re-roll two successes (significant exhaustion, mental fog)
 - 4 Collapse, KO, or spiritual break (incapacitated)
-

Clearing Fatigue

Recovery requires genuine respite:

- A night's rest with adequate Supply removes 1 Fatigue.
- Fatigue cannot be removed while the party is Dangerously Low or Out of Supply.
- Medical attention (Presence + Heal, DV 2) during downtime can remove 1 Fatigue.

Narrative note: Fatigue is not only physical—it can reflect mental strain, grief, or spiritual exhaustion. A failed ritual might leave a caster at Fatigue 2 from metaphysical backlash alone.

Fatigue → Harm Conversion

Each character has a Fatigue track equal to their **Body** attribute. When the track fills:

1. Increase Harm by one level (0→Harm 1, Harm 1→Harm 2, Harm 2→Harm 3).
2. Clear all Fatigue.

This conversion can occur multiple times in a scene. (See Player's Guide for full Harm rules.)

3.3 Boons: The Currency of Resilience

Boons are narrative tokens earned by embracing risk. They reward *failure with opportunity*—the silver lining in clouds of defeat.

Earning Boons

Boons flow to those who engage deeply with the world:

- On a **Partial** (1 Boon) or **Miss** (2 Boons) with meaningful consequences (see Fail Forward, Player's Guide).
- Through clever or risky roleplay that drives the story.
- Via bond-driven actions with intricate descriptions.
- By GM discretion for exceptional collaborative play.

Boon Economy

- **Holding cap:** Maximum 5 Boons.
- **Carryover:** At end of each scene, reduce held Boons to a maximum of 2 (excess lost).
- **Conversion:** Once per session during downtime, convert 2 Boons $\rightarrow$ 1 XP (max 2 XP per session via conversion).

Spending Boons

Players may spend 1 Boon to:

- Re-roll a single die (after seeing the pool).
- Activate an on-screen Asset.
- Improve Position by one step before a roll.
- Power certain Rites or abilities.

Anti-Fishing Measures (GM Guidance)

- **Once/Scene Cap:** At most 2 Boons from failures per character per scene.
- **Repetition Rule:** Same approach + same stakes in the same scene cannot award another Boon.
- **Position Gate:** Dominant tests with trivial fallout do not award Boons.

Design note: Boons reward narrative risk, not repeated failure.

3.4 Followers and Assets: Power Beyond the Self

Players can invest XP in **Followers** (on-screen allies) and **Assets** (off-screen resources). These are story agents with their own motivations and risks.

Followers: On-Scene Allies

Followers are bought with XP and tracked by a **Cap** (maximum assist bonus). Cost = Cap^2 XP; downtime 1–3 days to recruit.

3.4.0.0.1 Assisting in Scenes

- Assist dice equal $\min(\text{Cap}, \text{helper's relevant Skill})$.
- Total assist from all sources capped at +3 dice (except *Exceptional Coordination* talent allows +4 from one follower).
- Only one follower may assist a given action.

3.4.0.0.2 Follower Initiative Actions Once per scene (party-wide), a follower may take a small independent action:

- **Scout & Signal** – Change an ally’s next action to Dominant.
- **Distract & Draw** – Reduce a threat/hunt/escape clock by 1 tick.
- **Fetch & Carry** – Move a small object through danger.

Cost: Mark Exposure +1 or Harm 1 on that follower.

3.4.0.0.3 Follower Upkeep Each downtime:

- Pay XP equal to Cap **or** spend a scene tending the relationship.
- Neglect → follower becomes *Wary* (or *Seized* if already *Wary*).
- If the GM spends 2+ SB on an action you take with assistance, they may mark Exposure or Harm on the follower instead of other consequences (fiction first).
- **Off-Screen Capability:** Once per downtime, a Cap 3+ follower can solve a significant problem but generates 1 SB for the party (the GM describes the resulting complication).

3.4.0.0.4 Follower Condition Followers track two meters:

Exposure – Attention, stress, narrative pressure.

Harm – Injury, trauma, damage.

State: *Maintained* (full) → *Neglected* (–1 die) → *Compromised* (unavailable).

Assets: Off-Scene Influence

Assets are titles, safehouses, spy rings, charters. They do not act in scenes directly but change the fiction between sessions.

[Asset Tiers] IX

Tier Cost and Examples

Minor 4 XP (1 day) – safehouse, small shop, local contact.

Standard 8 XP (1 week) – noble title, spy ring, workshop.

Major 12 XP (1 month) – city license, fortress lease, regional network.

3.4.0.0.5 Using Assets

- **Off-Screen Effect:** Use once per session for free (the quiet work between adventures).
- **On-Screen Activation:** Spend 1 Boon to use the asset dramatically in a scene.
- **Downtime Activation:** Pay 2 XP or 1 Boon to activate an asset at campaign start or during downtime.
- Asset must have plausible scope for the intended effect.

3.4.0.0.6 Asset Upkeep Each downtime:

- **Efficient (higher XP, less time):** Cost = $\max(1, XP_{Acquisition}/3)$. Minimal effort.
- **Intensive (lower XP, more time):** Cost = 1 XP. Requires a dedicated downtime action with significant personal involvement.
- Failure to pay → asset becomes *Neglected* (or *Compromised* if already *Neglected*).

3.4.0.0.7 Asset Condition

Maintained – Full capability.

Neglected – –1 die when used; requires attention.

Compromised – Unavailable until repaired or recovered.

3.5 XP Awards: Growth Through Choice

XP is earned through genuine engagement, not attendance. Use these guidelines at the end of each session.

[XP Award Guidelines] IX

Award Range

Table Attendance +2 XP

Major Objective +2–4 XP

Discovery / Lore +1–2 XP

Hard Choice +1–2 XP

Complication Spotlight +1–3 XP

Bond / Flag Driven Play +1–2 XP

GM Curveball +0–3 XP

Milestones

At the end of a major story arc:

- +8–12 XP to all players.
- +2 XP bonus to one player for a signature moment of the arc.

3.6 Campaign Resources: Mandate and Crisis

Two campaign-level clocks track the party's influence and the world's resistance.

Mandate Clock (0–6)

Tracks the party's public legitimacy.

- **High Mandate:** Allies seek them out, resources flow, doors open.
- **Low Mandate:** Suspicion, bureaucratic obstacles, support withers.

Crisis Clock (0–6)

Tracks the opposition's growing strength.

- **Rising Crisis:** Complications escalate, enemies grow bolder.
- **Managed Crisis:** Breathing room, opportunities to strike back.

3.7 Combat Resource Management

In combat, resource management takes on desperate urgency.

Supply in Combat

- **Intense Combat:** GM may spend 1 SB to fill 1 Supply segment (arrows break, waterskins puncture).
- **Prolonged Engagement:** Each hour of sustained combat adds 1 Supply segment.
- **Ammunition Depletion:** Ranged weapons may run low, requiring scavenging actions.

Fatigue in Combat

- Characters with existing Fatigue re-roll additional successes equal to their Fatigue level each round.
- Reaching 4 Fatigue during combat causes immediate collapse.
- Fatigue cannot be cleared during active combat.

Follower Combat Integration

- Followers assist using their Cap.
- 2+ SB spent in combat can endanger an assisting follower (mark Exposure or Harm).
- Followers can take combat-relevant independent actions (cost: Exposure +1 or Harm 1).
- After a follower acts twice in a high-risk combat scene, mark Exposure +1.

Tactical Clocks

Tactical clocks represent persistent combat conditions that drain party resources.

[Tactical Clock Effects] IX

Clock Resource Drain

Mob Overwhelm [6] Accelerates Supply depletion and Fatigue.

Fatigue Spiral [4] Accelerates existing Fatigue, makes each action harder.

Morale Collapse [6] Generates SB, reduces effectiveness.

Environmental Collapse [8] Creates new Supply and safety concerns.

Over-Stack Trigger

- If the party **enters** a scene with ≥ 3 structural advantages, the GM *may* apply Over-Stack once for that scene.
- Choose: start one obstacle at +1 DV, **or** bank +1 SB for the first Deck Twist.
- Over-Stack applies only to advantages held at scene framing, not those generated through play.

3.8 Narrative First: The Fiction Is the Ledger

In Fate's Edge, arrows, rations, and waterskins are tracked only in the fiction that surrounds them. Mechanics engage only when those resources become scarce enough to matter. The focus remains always on **narrative tension**—the gnawing hunger, the fading light, the last arrow—not sterile bookkeeping.

Let the world breathe with its own needs and abundances. Let the fiction lead through scarcity and surplus. And when the dice say the world pushes back against mortal plans—**listen to what they tell you about the price of ambition.**

Chapter 4

Magic and Backlash

In **Fate's Edge**, magic is not a clean or safe art practiced in sterile towers. It is a **dangerous negotiation with forces beyond mortal comprehension**. As the GM, your role is to make magic **feel weighty, thematic, and alive with risk**. This chapter provides tools for adjudicating magical actions, managing consequences, and keeping the story at the forefront.

*For player-facing rules (spellcasting, Rites, Invoker symbols, Cantor songs, etc.), see the **Player's Guide**. This chapter focuses on your role as GM.*

4.1 The Role of Magic in Your Game

Magic in Fate's Edge is:

- **Consequential** – Every spell can change the fiction, for good or ill.
- **Risky** – Even success may generate Story Beats (SB) that you spend to complicate the moment.
- **Thematic** – Backlash should reflect the elements and Patrons involved.
- **Creative** – Reward inventive uses, but keep scope within the players' tier.

Your primary job is not to block magic, but to **frame costs, apply consequences, and escalate drama**. When a player wants to cast a spell, ask:

- What do they want to achieve?
- Which elements or Patrons are involved?
- What is at stake if it goes wrong?

4.2 Adjudicating Magic at the Table

Setting Difficulty Value (DV) and Position

Use the standard DV ladder (2–5+), but consider magical specifics:

[DV for Magic] IX

DV When to Use

2 Routine cantrip, minor sensory effect, no opposition.

- 3 Standard combat spell, small environmental change, contested but fair.
- 4 Complex working, area effect, strong opposition, dangerous ritual.
- 5+ Legendary magic, rewriting reality, binding a major Outsider.

4.2.0.0.1 Position for Magic

- **Dominant:** Caster has ritual preparation, rare components, or surprise.
- **Controlled:** Standard casting under normal conditions.
- **Desperate:** Caster is wounded, rushed, or in an anti-magic zone.

Position affects the severity of backlash (see below).

Range Bands for Magic

Spells and effects have natural range limits based on their tags and fiction. Use these guidelines:

Range Band	Typical Spells
Close	Touch, personal aura, short cone.
Near	Same room/zone, thrown magics, most combat spells.
Far	Across a battlefield, line of sight without obstacles.
Absent	Ritual scrying, long-distance teleportation (requires setup).

4.2.0.0.2 Adjusting Range: A spell can be extended one band by increasing DV by 1, adding a SB, or requiring an extra action. Extreme range (e.g., scrying a distant city) should be a ritual, not a single roll.

When to Say Yes, No, or Yes, But

- **Yes:** Effect is clearly within the caster's tier, tags, and fictional logic.
- **No:** The effect would break the campaign premise, destroy a mystery, or invalidate another player's niche. Offer alternatives.
- **Yes, But:** The effect works, but at a cost: increased DV, higher SB generation, a clock, or an immediate narrative complication.

Handling Creative Player Ideas

When a player tries something unexpected:

1. Listen to the description. What do they want to achieve?
2. Ask for the tags or elements involved. If none, help them add one.
3. Set DV and Position based on scope and risk.
4. Clearly state the stakes: "If you fail, the spell will backfire and also alert the guards."
5. Let the dice decide, then spend SB to make the outcome interesting.

4.3 Story Beats and Backlash (GM Tools)

Every time a player rolls a 1 on a magical action, you gain Story Beats (SB). Spend them to create backlash – complications that fit the magic's element and the fiction.

SB Spend Menu for Magic

[Spend SB on Magical Complications] IX

SB Cost Example Backlash

-
- 1 SB Minor flare, eerie sound, brief sensory distortion, gear lightly scorched.
 2 SB Backlash harms an ally (Fatigue 1), spell draws attention, caster loses balance (Position -1).
 3 SB Patron omen, secondary target affected, magical feedback (Harm 1 to caster).
 4+ SB Reality warps – zone gains a temporary tag, Patron manifests a demand, a new threat appears.
-

Elemental Backlash Examples

Use these to color your complications:

Element	Sample Backlash
Fire	Smoke, heat exhaustion, small secondary fire, blinding flare.
Water	Flooding, slippery footing, emotional surge, dampness ruining supplies.
Earth	Tremor, dust cloud, immobilising stone grip, cracked floor.
Air	Sudden gust, deafening thunder, scatters important items, voice lost.
Fate	Prophetic nightmare, doors close, a crucial option disappears.
Luck	Allied misfortune, fragile success, random complication.
Life	Overgrowth, healing surge on enemy, parasitic plants.
Death	Ghostly whisper, chill, memory loss, premature decay.

Backlash Severity by Position

Position	Backlash Severity on Partial/Miss
Dominant	Minor – one SB complication, manageable cost.
Controlled	Moderate – 1–2 SB complication, temporary setback.
Desperate	Severe – 2–3 SB complication, lasting consequences or Harm.

4.4 Managing Obligation and Corruption

Players track their own Obligation and Corruption, but you enforce thresholds and create consequences.

Obligation Overflow and Patron Intrusions

When a character exceeds their Obligation Capacity (Spirit + Presence):

- For each segment over capacity, mark 1 Fatigue (player does this).
- If they exceed ****double capacity****, clear all Fatigue, mark Harm 1, and trigger a **Patron Intrusion** – a narrative demand or complication from the Patron.

4.4.0.0.1 Examples of Patron Intrusions

- The Patron appears in a dream: “Do this task for me, or else.”
- A rival servant of the same Patron arrives to collect a debt.
- The Patron’s mark becomes visible on the character’s skin, causing social trouble.
- A faction aligned with the Patron forcibly recruits the character.

Corruption as a Narrative Track

Corruption (Cantors, Pact-Whisperers) fills from pushes, resonant rites, and your SB spends. When the clock fills:

- Apply the Patron’s “benefit and burden” (see Patron tables in Player’s Guide).
- Reset the clock to the character’s Tier minimum.
- If the player embraces corruption, give them a permanent thematic quirk (not a pure penalty).

4.5 Summoning (GM-Facing)

For full summoning mechanics, see the Player’s Guide (Pact-Whisperer). Here are your key responsibilities:

What to Watch For

- **Leash ticking:** Tick the Leash whenever the spirit takes Harm, acts against its nature, the summoner splits focus, or the spirit crosses a [WARD] (test DV = Cap).
- **Boon Finesse:** Players may spend 1 Boon once per round to clear 1 tick (before the Leash fills).
- **Quick Commands:** Simple orders (attack nearest, hold, fetch) do not cost the summoner’s action. Complex commands do.

When the Spirit Acts on Its Own

On a Miss, or when the Leash fills, the spirit acts once according to its nature before departing (or turning hostile). Use this to introduce a complication:

- A fire elemental sets the nearest structure ablaze.
- A shadow spirit whispers a secret to an enemy.
- A guardian spirit defends the wrong person.

Spirit Specializations (Quick Reference)

If a player develops a bonded spirit, you may grant one specialization from this list:

- **Combat:** +1 Harm melee, ignore first Harm on attacks.
- **Scout:** Stealthy; Cap 1 carries 2kg, Cap 3 carries 10kg.
- **Utility:** Simple tasks (carrying, opening doors).
- **Shield:** Interpose; convert Harm to Fatigue.

4.6 Cantors and Corruption (GM Guidance)

Cantors use Songs (Low Rites) with a Corruption Clock. Your main tasks:

- Track the Corruption Clock only when the player marks it (they manage it).
- On a fill, impose the last Patron’s benefit burden (from Patron tables).
- Spend SB to represent social fallout, Patron omens, or magical residue from their performances.

Inspire Chorus

Once per scene, a Cantor can shift all allies’ Position +1 for one exchange. If they use it again in the same scene, they mark toward Corruption accumulation. This is a non-stacking aura; only the best shift applies.

Chorus Cults (Optional)

If a Cantor performs a Resonant Rite before 10+ witnesses, they may found a Chorus. This grants a minor follower benefit, but they must mark Obligation each session they use it. If neglected, the cult fractures – you can introduce a rival sect or a scandal.

4.7 Ritual Magic (GM Advice)

Rituals are powerful but slow. Use them for effects that are too big for a single roll.

Setting DV for Rituals

- **Low Ritual (DV 3–4):** 10–15 minutes, affects a room or small area.
- **Standard Ritual (DV 4–5):** 30 minutes, affects a building or a scene.
- **High Ritual (DV 5+):** Hours, affects a district or narrative turning point.

Using Helpers

Helpers can reduce DV by 1 each (max –2) or absorb 1 SB of backlash. They must have relevant skills (Arcana, Lore, etc.). Interrupting a helper may disrupt the ritual.

Pacing and Interruption

If a ritual is interrupted, treat as a Miss on the casting roll. You may also:

- Advance a doomsday clock.
- Summon an unexpected entity.
- Damage a needed component.

4.8 Psionics (Optional) – GM Sidebar

Adjudicating Psionics

Psionics is power without intermediaries – no Patrons, no symbols. As GM, ensure it feels precise yet costly.

Core Principles:

- Set DV by precision, not raw power. Clear intent = lower DV.
- Generate SB frequently – mental strain, sensory bleed, NPC suspicion.
- Respect consent: unwilling minds always resist.
- On Partial, offer hard choices: surface thoughts only, emotional truth without context.
- Distinguish from spellcraft: psionics excels at direct influence, not environmental change.

Example Backlash: headache, nosebleed, fleeting vision, target becomes aware of intrusion, caster loses focus (Fatigue 1).

4.9 Quick Reference Tables (GM Only)

Spend SB for Magical Complications

SB	Effect
1	Minor flare, noise, caster off-balance (–1 die next action).
2	Backlash harms an ally (Fatigue 1), draws attention, Position –1.
3	Patron omen, magical feedback (Harm 1), new clock (e.g., “Leaking Energy”).
4+	Reality warp, Patron manifestation, scene shifts (fire, flood, etc.).

Elemental Backlash Quick Picks

Element	Minor (1–2 SB)	Major (3+ SB)
Fire	Smoke, sparks	Uncontrolled fire, explosion
Water	Slick floor, damp	Flooding, emotional storm
Earth	Dust, tremor	Collapse, binding
Air	Gust, ringing ears	Hurricane, deafness
Fate	Option closes	Prophecy becomes fixed
Luck	Small misfortune	A friend suffers the failure
Life	Overgrowth	Parasite, fever
Death	Chill whispers	A ghost manifests

Patron Intrusion Examples

Patron Type	Sample Intrusion
Everflame (Oath)	“Prove your purity – destroy that heretical text.”
The Traveler	“You must guide a lost soul to their destination.”
Inquisitor Prime	“Report any unsanctioned magic you witness.”
Malachai	“Curse someone weaker than you before dawn.”

Final GM Reminder

Magic is a narrative engine. Use Story Beats to create drama, not to punish. When in doubt, let the spell work and complicate the result. The world should react – but always in a way that keeps the story moving.

“Set the DV low. Spend SB to make the cost visible. Let the fiction lead.”